Étienne Geoffroy Saint-Hilaire — Philosophie anatomique (1818–1822)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Étienne Geoffroy Saint-Hilaire, who became professor of zoology at the Paris Museum at twenty-one and served as a savant on Napoleon's Egypt expedition. In his *Philosophie anatomique* he argued that all animals are built on one plan, and that claim made him Cuvier's great antagonist. Their debate at the Academy in 1830 split the scientific world, with Goethe taking Geoffroy's side from Weimar. The end of his own story is the hardest part of the record: a stroke in 1840 left him blind and paralysed, he resigned his chair in 1841, and he died in 1844 with the system unfinished in the form he meant to give it. This presentation is dedicated to the man who spent his life looking for one pattern in all animals, and who lost his sight before that work was done.

The author's own terms

Unity of composition, in Geoffroy's sense, means that all vertebrates — indeed, all animals — are built on one plan, part answering to part by position and connection.

The story

Étienne Geoffroy Saint-Hilaire (1772–1844) became professor of zoology at the

Paris Museum at twenty-one, and served as a savant — a learned scientific specialist — on Napoleon's Egypt expedition. His *Philosophie anatomique*, published in two volumes (the first in 1818, on the respiratory organs and the vertebrate skeleton; the second in 1822, on human monstrosities), states his "unity of composition": all vertebrates — indeed, all animals — are built on one plan, part answering to part by position and connection. Around that claim he set out his laws of development, of compensation, and of relative position.

The claim made him Cuvier's great antagonist. Their famous debate at the Academy in 1830 split the scientific world, with Goethe taking Geoffroy's side from Weimar. The end of Geoffroy's own story is recorded plainly in the sources for this research. A stroke in 1840 left him blind and paralysed; he resigned his chair in 1841 and died in 1844, with the system unfinished in the form he meant to give it. His book, meanwhile, reached English readers only in the ways set out below: Darwin scholarship reads him in French, or in excerpt.

The work and what survives

Both volumes survive in the original French (Paris: Méquignon-Marvis), with scans on Internet Archive, Gallica, and the Biodiversity Heritage Library. The work is in the public domain: imprints of 1818 and 1822, and the author died in 1844.

A reviewer's check pins the collation. Volume 1 (1818) runs to xxxix + 517 pages, with an atlas of 10 plates covering 116 preparations. Volume 2 (1822), *Des monstruosités humaines*, is the teratology volume — teratology being the study of developmental abnormalities. A second-pass check corroborates Volume 2 at xxxiv + 550 pages, with an atlas of 7 plates.

The copy-text record is partly pinned and partly, honestly, not. The BnF digitisation itself is confirmed: the Hachette Livre–BnF reprints are made from the BnF and Gallica scan (text volume ISBN 9782019996994; plates volume ISBN 9782011905345). But the specific Gallica ARK was not surfaced — a reviewer's note records that Gallica's digitisation of the work is documented via the Hachette Livre–BnF programme while the specific ARK was not found, and a second-pass check records that the Gallica ARK was not surfaced in four search attempts, so no ARK is asserted; pulling it directly from Gallica remains a step before any edition is built, chiefly for the atlases. Verified working pins are these. Volume 2 (1822): Internet Archive `b21305304`, opened and verified, from the King's College London and St Thomas's copy, Public Domain Mark, OCLC

1045400760 — with the caution that **this copy is without plates**, so the Volume 2 atlas of 7 plates must come from HathiTrust or BnF at build time. Volume 1 (1818): full text at Rockefeller University DigitalCommons (Rare Books 164), with HathiTrust page images per the Online Books Page. A companion file in this collection treats the founding sequel by the author's son, Isidore Geoffroy Saint-Hilaire's *Traité de tératologie*.

Its English fortunes

English-language sources — Britannica, the ASU Embryo Project, and the 1884 *Popular Science Monthly* life — describe the work's principles in detail but cite no English translation. A reviewer's check confirms the excerpts-only picture from the review literature: Hervé Le Guyader's *Geoffroy Saint-Hilaire: A Visionary Naturalist*, translated by Marjorie Grene, contains translations that a review specifies are excerpts from *Philosophie anatomique* and *Principes de philosophie zoologique* (1830), plus two memoirs — not a complete *Philosophie anatomique*.

The bounded finding of this research, verified on 14 October 2026, is this: **No complete English translation found after research.** Volume 2, the teratology volume, is the more self-contained first instalment.

What completing it would take

Completing the work would mean a fresh translation from the French, taking Volume 2 (monstrosities) or Volume 1 (organs of respiration and the skeleton) first, since each stands alone, with the anatomical plates reproduced as image matter. The review standard set for it is a historian of morphology together with a French reader.

Sources

- https://embryo.asu.edu/pages/etienne-geoffroy-saint-hilaire-1772-1844 (ASU Embryo Project: the work, its principles, its influence on Owen and Darwin studies)
- http://www.britannica.com/biography/Etienne-Geoffroy-Saint-Hilaire (the two volumes, the three laws, the 1830 debate, the 1840 stroke and blindness)
- https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/%C3%89tienne_Geoffroy_Saint-Hilaire (Popular Science Monthly, Jan. 1884: the career and the 1818/1822 publication)

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